

Stephen Hawking with his wife Jane and their son Timothy in Cambridge, England, in 1980. [Photo by Kip Thorne.]

Hawking contracted ALS in 1963, soon after he began graduate school at Cambridge University. ALS is a catch-all name for a variety of motor neuron diseases, most of which kill fairly quickly. Thinking he had only a few years to live, Hawking at first lost his enthusiasm for life and physics. However, by the winter of 1964–65, it became apparent that his was a rare variant of ALS, a variant that saps the central nervous system's control of muscles over many years' time, not just a few. Suddenly life seemed wonderful. He returned to physics with greater vigor and enthusiasm than he had ever had as a healthy, devil-may-care undergraduate student; and with his new lease on life, he married Jane Wilde, whom he had met shortly after contracting ALS and with whom he had fallen in love during the early phases of his disease.

Stephen's marriage to Jane was essential to his success and happiness in the 1960s and 1970s and into the 1980s. She made for them a normal home and a normal life in the midst of physical adversity.

The happiest smile I ever saw in my life was Stephen's the evening in August 1972 in the French Alps when Jane, I, and the Hawkings' two oldest children, Robert and Lucy, returned from a day's excursion into the mountains. Through foolishness we had missed the last ski lift down the